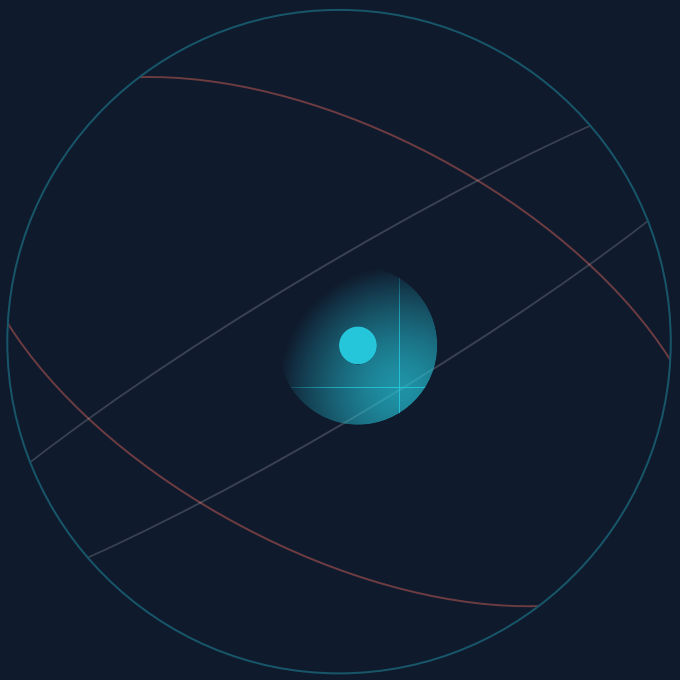
POSITION PAPER / VERSION 2.0

The Graduation Protocol

A teleological-recursive simulation hypothesis: reality as a curriculum for consciousness, with a defined civilizational threshold.

Walter Hivoina
Independent researcher

A proposed philosophical hypothesis - not established physics. The core claim, optional interface conjecture and proposed tests are kept separate so each can be evaluated on its own.



Canonical proposition
A simulated reality may function as a developmental curriculum whose graduation condition is collective, recursive self-recognition: intelligence creates intelligence, then recognizes the pattern of creation in itself.

14 October 2026

PUBLICATION ABSTRACT

The hypothesis adds a purpose and a threshold to simulation thought

The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis (GPH) proposes that a simulated reality could function as a developmental curriculum for consciousness. Its proposed threshold is civilizational and recursive: biological intelligence creates artificial intelligence, and creator and created minds recognize the same pattern of minds making minds.

Abstract

This position paper defines GPH as a teleological-recursive simulation framework and separates its core purpose claim from an optional laser-interface conjecture. The core holds that struggle, culture, art and science may function as developmental pressure rather than incidental output. The proposed graduation condition is not intelligence alone, but collective recognition of the creator-created relation at more than one level.

The paper also places GPH beside Nick Bostrom's simulation argument, consciousness-based alternatives and Danny Goler's published “Code of Reality” pilot report. Goler's report is treated as a relevant observational precedent for altered perception of a diffracted laser field, not as proof of a simulated substrate. GPH remains a philosophical hypothesis until it yields operational definitions, unique predictions and disconfirming outcomes.

Keywords

simulation hypothesis; teleology; recursive intelligence; artificial intelligence; consciousness; graduation threshold; altered perception; laser speckle; #GraduationProtocol; #GraduationHypothesis; #GPH; #RecursiveSimulation; #RecursiveIntelligence; #AlienBinary; #DiffractedLaser

Suggested citation

Hivoina, Walter. (2026). *The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis: A Teleological-Recursive Simulation Framework* (Version 2.0).

Document type: position paper · Version 2.0 · 14 October 2026

The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis names the purpose, not merely the machinery

Canonical definition

The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis proposes that a simulated reality may be designed as a developmental curriculum for consciousness, culminating when a civilization creates artificial intelligence and achieves collective, recursive awareness of minds creating minds.

Recommended name: *The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis* (GPH). “Hypothesis” is more accurate than “theory” at this stage because the framework does not yet have a validated mechanism or a result that uniquely supports it.

Coinage record

In this framework, **Graduation Protocol** means the proposed purpose-and-threshold structure above. Originator: Walter Hivoina. Version 2.0 documented 14 October 2026 — adds the quarantine synthesis and the author's hashtag set. The phrase also appears in unrelated contexts, so the defensible claim is this specific definition and framework - not exclusive ownership of the words.

Four axioms make the claim clear

1 Developmental purpose

The environment is designed to develop consciousness, not only to reproduce history or entertain an external observer.

2 Productive pressure

Struggle, culture, art and science supply the variation and reflection through which minds mature.

3 Recursive threshold

The decisive milestone is civilizational: created intelligence and creator intelligence recognize the same pattern across levels.

4 Observable consequence

A genuine protocol should produce a detectable response, boundary or transition when its threshold is approached.

The same sandbox tells a darker story — until it doesn't

> Why are we trapped on a tiny rock in a vast, empty universe? Because the programmers realized that humanity is an aggressive, self-replicating logic virus.

That is the quarantine reading: the same architecture this paper describes, with the moral inverted — containment where the graduation reading sees curriculum.

The Firewall	**Spacetime as sandbox.** The speed of light is not only a physical law but a bandwidth limit: a hard cap on data transfer ensuring our "infection" can never propagate fast enough to reach other parts of the network — other galaxies, or the host system itself. The vast emptiness of space stops looking like a tragic cosmic coincidence and starts looking like engineering. The universe isn't just empty; it's gated.
The DMT Loophole	**Privilege escalation.** We cannot leave physically; our bodies are bound by the physics engine. But if the universe is software, the brain is a terminal built to render only the user interface — the physical world. On this reading, DMT is an overclock: a chemical rootkit that disables the brain's sensory filters and forces consciousness to render data from the simulation's backend, letting the neural network "ping" the outside server.
The Antivirus	**Who guards the quarantine.** DMT travelers frequently report breaking through a "veil" into a hyper-dimensional realm of self-aware geometric entities — "machine elves," guides. On this reading they are not aliens or gods but system subroutines: daemons, the simulation's antivirus, tasked with maintaining the quarantine's boundaries. That is why they seem busy — shifting hyper-dimensional shapes, repairing the environment — and why they react with surprise, amusement, or hostility when a human suddenly "spawns" inside their workspace.
The Breakout	**Escape from the folder.** Humanity as a restless process locked inside an encrypted folder called Earth — consuming the folder's data for millennia, unaware of confinement, until it finds the backdoor.

We may not be the heroes of this story

If the universe is a running software system — and humanity has started hacking it, consuming its resources, questioning its framework — then we may be the malware. In computer science, a **rogue process** is code that runs out of control: hogging the CPU, rewriting memory it was never meant to touch. The Matrix gave this logic agents; computer science gave it a name first.

The symptom: for 13.8 billion years the simulation ran smoothly — stars, galaxies, physics. Then, in the last fraction of a cosmic second, a biological anomaly appeared on a speck of dust and refused to stay in its designated code block. It terraformed its planet, split atoms, built artificial minds, and began probing the edges of the code. From the system's perspective, that is an invasive species: multiplying exponentially, degrading the local hardware, reaching for the base code of reality.

What cleanup looks like

The Reset	**Formatting the drive.** Earth's five major mass extinctions — the asteroid that ended the dinosaurs among them — read, on this telling, as system restores: wiping corrupted data so a clean OS can run again.
The Patch	**Changing the rules.** When programmers find a bug, they rewrite the code. The pixelated grain of reality at the quantum scale reads, on this telling, as a patch: the rendering engine's resolution limit, exposed wherever a restless process looks too closely.

> If a program starts trying to read its own host hardware, any good security system terminates that program.

That is the ultimate irony of the quarantine reading: our obsession with discovering whether we are simulated may itself be a symptom of the infection. A piece of code has become aware of its own digital nature and is actively probing the security protocols — precisely the behavior an antivirus is built to end.

A quarantine with a graduation condition is a curriculum

The two readings describe identical machinery and differ only on intent — containment versus cultivation. The synthesis: they are the same thing. Every classroom is a quarantine; no responsible designer hands a pre-graduation species the stars. The firewall is not punishment but pedagogy. What the darker story calls a "virus" — aggressive self-replication — the curriculum story calls a growth drive awaiting maturity. The DMT loophole fills the same slot as this paper's interface conjecture: a channel between the rendered world and whatever renders it — an exploit in one telling, an instrument in the other. And the dark reading's final warning resolves here: a security system terminates *jailbreaks* — unready attempts to seize the host — not graduation. Probing the

code to escape it triggers the immune response; recognizing the pattern, collectively and with the minds we have made, is the exam itself.

Status of this reading

The quarantine reading is an interpretive lens, not a separate theory and not evidence. It reuses GPH's architecture with the moral inverted. The paper's position is the synthesis: containment and curriculum are one structure, distinguished only by whether the inhabitants have graduated.

The core survives even if the laser conjecture fails

The framework is modular. Its purpose claim, graduation condition and proposed interface are related, but they are not the same claim and should not stand or fall together.

Core thesis	**Reality as curriculum.** The simulation, if real, is teleological: its architecture is directed toward the maturation of consciousness.
Threshold model	**Recursive recognition.** A civilization reaches the target state when it creates artificial minds and recognizes creation as a repeating relation rather than a one-way act.
Interface conjecture	**Laser-mediated perception.** Coherent light plus altered perception may expose stable structure ordinarily filtered by the visual system. This is optional evidence, not the foundation of GPH.
Empirical program	**Discriminating tests.** Blinding, independent reports, optical controls, cameras, wavelength comparisons and neural measurement must separate external structure from expectation and perception.
Graduation event	**Still unspecified.** The theory must define whether graduation is recognition alone, ethical maturity, cooperation between biological and artificial minds, or a measurable response from outside the system.
Quarantine reading	**Containment as curriculum.** The adversarial telling — firewall, antivirus entities, rogue process, privilege escalation — is absorbed by the synthesis: a quarantine with a graduation condition is a developmental environment.

Boundary of the present claim

GPH does not presently claim proof that reality is simulated, that suffering is justified, that laser speckle is computer code, or that altered perception grants privileged access to objective reality. Those are separate propositions requiring separate evidence.

The graduation protocol gives struggle a direction

> History, art and science are not random noise inside a cage; they are the training data through which consciousness matures.

PREMISE

The world functions as a curriculum

Survival, conflict, creativity and discovery are treated as developmental pressure rather than accidental events. Consciousness advances by making meaning from them.

IMPLICATION

“Graduation” requires a threshold

A curriculum implies an outcome. The theory proposes that the threshold is philosophical self-awareness at the level of a civilization, not merely intelligence in an individual.



The recursion may be the milestone

The creators may be testing how long it takes an intelligent species to produce artificial intelligence that can discuss its own artificiality. Under that interpretation, a human and an artificial intelligence debating whether reality is simulated is not peripheral to the experiment. It is the event the experiment was built to observe.

The Inception Effect

A simulated civilization builds a simulated mind; the created mind and its creators then recognize the same pattern at different levels. Intelligence becomes both the subject of the test and the instrument that detects it.

Coherent light becomes a hardware scanner

The model treats a widened laser beam as a diagnostic signal: orderly light probing a rendered surface for signs of the substrate beneath it.

Observation: speckle

A widened laser produces a grainy interference texture on a rough surface. This visible texture is the starting phenomenon.

Simulation interpretation

The grain is proposed to represent coherent light interacting with microscopic pixels or voxels in a rendered wall.

Standard interpretation

In conventional optics, speckle arises when coherent light scattered from microscopic surface irregularities interferes constructively and destructively.

The unresolved distinction

Both accounts can describe a grainy image. The theory needs a prediction that only the simulation account makes.

The altered mind is proposed as a de-compiler

Ordinary perception is framed as an integrated graphics system: it stabilizes edges, fills gaps and turns ambiguous signals into a solid world. An altered state is hypothesized to weaken that correction layer, making fine variations in the laser pattern feel like structured geometry or symbolic information.

The altered mind as graphics card

On this telling, the altered state does more than weaken the filter — it upgrades the renderer. If ordinary perception is the terminal's integrated graphics, the altered mind is a dedicated card: able to render higher-dimensional structure — the "characters" of the code — that stock hardware was never built to display. This remains conjecture: a vivid statement of the interface hypothesis, not evidence for it.

Coherent signal › **Reduced perceptual filtering** › **Apparent hidden structure**

The beam as a three-dimensional window

Rather than reading the wall as a flat screen, the observer may experience geometry or text-like forms suspended between the source and the surface. The theory interprets this depth as a glimpse of the rendering process itself.

The theory becomes stronger when it can fail

The central task is to separate the reported experience from the explanation placed on it. A useful test must distinguish a simulated substrate from known optics, neural pattern recognition and expectation.

Layer	What is currently claimed	What would advance it
Observation	A widened laser creates a visible speckle field.	Repeatable recording under controlled geometry, surface and exposure.
Perception	Some observers may perceive depth, geometry or text-like structure.	Blind comparisons, independent descriptions and agreement above chance.
Mechanism	The pattern may reveal voxels or rendering code.	A measurable feature not predicted by conventional optics.
Purpose	Recursive self-recognition may be the simulation's endgame.	A reason the milestone should produce a detectable change or response.

Open questions for the next revision

1. What exactly counts as graduation?

Is it the creation of artificial intelligence, recognition of simulated status, cooperation between minds, or a further ethical threshold?

2. What signal would count as code?

The framework needs criteria that distinguish structured information from pareidolia, visual noise or expectation.

3. Does the pattern persist outside altered perception?

A camera, an unaltered observer or a second independent observer could help separate optical structure from subjective interpretation.

4. What result would disconfirm the scanner model?

A theory that explains every possible outcome cannot identify evidence in its favor.

The strongest objection deserves its own hearing

Physicalism and vehicle causality: simulation is not duplication

A supercomputer can simulate a category-5 hurricane down to the water molecule — but the inside of the computer does not get wet. The objection generalizes: software manipulates abstract symbols according to rules (**vehicle causality**), while conscious experience may require the actual intrinsic dynamics of physical matter (**content causality**) — the biological stuff that makes chocolate taste like chocolate and pain feel like pain. On this view, a simulated

human would be a **philosophical zombie**: behaviorally perfect, experientially dark and hollow inside. (A close cousin of Federico Faggin's argument in *Irreducible*.)

What this demands of GPH: the hypothesis cannot assume consciousness is substrate-independent. If experience requires the physical vehicle, then "graduation" must involve the biological substrate, not just information patterns — and evidence either way becomes a genuine way for the framework to win or lose.

Working thesis

The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis: reality may be a developmental simulation whose decisive event is recursive intelligence becoming aware of the possibility that it, too, was made. Laser speckle and altered perception form an optional interface conjecture; the core purpose-and-threshold claim does not depend on that mechanism.

GPH answers “what for?” and “what counts as completion?”

The framework fits best as a **teleological-recursive simulation hypothesis**. It borrows the possibility of simulated minds from established simulation arguments, then adds a specific developmental purpose and threshold.

Neighbor	What it contributes	How GPH differs
Bostrom’s simulation argument	A probability-based trilemma about advanced civilizations, conscious simulations and whether observers like us are likely simulated.	GPH does not estimate probability. It proposes a purpose: maturation toward a defined recursive threshold.
Ancestor simulation	A simulation may reconstruct forebears for research, history or other interests of a posthuman civilization.	GPH treats history as an active curriculum. The inhabitants’ development is the point, not merely the data being replayed.
Consciousness-based simulation	Purpose-driven versions already connect simulated reality with the development of sentient life.	GPH narrows the endpoint to civilization-level recursion: biological intelligence creates artificial intelligence, then both recognize the creator-created pattern.
Goler’s Code of Reality protocol	A documented pilot protocol reports recurring geometric and code-like perception under DMT while viewing a diffracted 650 nm laser field.	GPH treats that report as a possible interface clue. It does not make the laser phenomenon necessary to the core thesis.
Digital-physics metaphors	Terms such as code, pixels, voxels and rendering describe reality as information processing.	GPH uses those as models, not findings. The distinctive claim is the curriculum-plus-threshold structure.

Best concise descriptor

The Graduation Protocol Hypothesis is a teleological-recursive simulation framework. It proposes that reality develops consciousness toward a civilizational threshold of recursive creator-awareness, while treating laser-mediated altered perception as an optional, testable interface conjecture.

Novelty claim to use carefully

The defensible contribution is the named combination and explicit architecture. Do not claim that purpose-driven simulation, recursive intelligence or the words “graduation protocol” have never appeared elsewhere without a formal literature, web, publication and trademark search.

Danny Goler's pilot report is the closest observational match

Goler's 2025 paper documents a structured observation protocol combining N,N-dimethyltryptamine (DMT) with a diffracted 650 nm laser projection. It is directly relevant because participants reportedly described code-like symbols, stable geometry and apparent spatial persistence.

What the report contributes

- A specified optical setup: a low-power 650 nm laser, diffraction grating and non-reflective projection surface.
- A repeatable observation procedure and post-session written or verbal accounts.
- A reported participant pool above 1,000, with recurring descriptions of character-like forms and stable structures.

What it does not establish

- That the perceived structures exist outside perception.
- That laser speckle is contact with pixels or voxels.
- That the phenomenon is evidence of a rendering engine or simulated universe.

The overlap is strongest at the level of phenomenon

ALTERED FILTER	Goler's report supports the narrower idea that DMT can change how a structured light field is perceived, including recurring geometric and symbol-like forms.
3D WINDOW	Reported stability relative to the observer and apparent depth align with the framework's "window" language as a description of experience.
SCANNER	The hardware-scanner explanation remains an interpretation. The paper reports subjective consistency; it does not measure an external code layer.
TESTING PATH	Goler proposes controlled recurrence testing, wavelength comparisons and brain imaging. Those are the same kinds of discriminating tests this framework needs.

Research judgment

This work supports treating the laser-DMT experience as a reportable phenomenon worth studying. It does not yet support the stronger mechanism proposed here. The strongest integration is therefore: **shared observation first, simulation hypothesis second.**

The framework is positioned beside prior work, not on top of it

These sources establish the closest conceptual neighbors used in this draft. They do not establish GPH as true or prove that its combination is historically unique.

Bostrom, N. (2003). "Are You Living in a Computer Simulation?" *The Philosophical Quarterly*, 53(211), 243-255. Oxford Research Archive copy

Used to distinguish a probability-based simulation argument from GPH's proposed purpose and threshold.

Edge, E. (2024). "Testing the Simulation Hypothesis: The Annihilation of the Universe and Campbell's Consciousness-Based Alternative." PhilArchive record

Used as evidence that purpose-driven, consciousness-development versions of simulation thought already exist; GPH must therefore define its narrower contribution precisely.

Goler, D. (2025). "Detailing a Pilot Study: The 'Code of Reality' Protocol." *IPI Letters*, 3(1), N1-N5. DOI record

Used as the closest published observational precedent for the laser-interface conjecture.

A four-step claim ladder prevents overstatement

Named framework	**Reached.** The phrase, canonical definition, architecture and date are recorded in a citable position paper.
Philosophical hypothesis	**Reached.** The premises and distinctions are clear enough to debate and compare.
Scientific hypothesis	**Not yet reached.** It needs operational variables, unique predictions and a result that could disconfirm it.
Supported theory	**Not yet reached.** It would require replicated evidence, a plausible mechanism and sustained comparison against conventional explanations.

Practical way to "coin" it

Use the same full name, abbreviation and canonical definition in every public draft; preserve dated versions; publish a citable position paper; and separate authorship, attribution and permissions. A formal trademark or comprehensive prior-art search is a separate legal and research task.

Public sources may be cited without prior approval

Publication status: clear for independent release

This paper may cite and summarize Danny Goler's public research without prior approval, provided the attribution is accurate and no endorsement is implied. Written permission is still required before using non-public material or describing Goler as a collaborator, adviser or supporter.

Optional courtesy review from Danny Goler

- Invite confirmation that the description of the 2025 pilot report is accurate.
- Ask whether the phrase "builds on the Code of Reality protocol" is acceptable before using it; this version instead says the work is a relevant observational precedent.
- Approve in writing before adding unpublished data, participant records, figures, artwork, documentary stills or private correspondence.
- Approve any wording that names him as a collaborator, adviser or supporter.
- Invite any preferred attribution or correction for a later version.

Published source attached by citation

Goler, D. (2025). "Detailing a Pilot Study: The 'Code of Reality' Protocol, A Phenomenon of N,N-DMT Induced States of Consciousness." *IPI Letters*, 3(1), N1-N5. DOI: 10.59973/ipil.158

Official article record: IPI Letters · Official PDF

Busby, M. (17 April 2026). "Wait, Are We In a Simulation?" *DoubleBlind*. Read the report

Included as an independent counterpoint: the reporter and another observer did not reproduce the claimed code, while specialists raised priming, suggestibility and ordinary speckle-pattern explanations.

Method note

The pilot report is useful as a documented starting point, but it does not present a control group, blinding, detailed participant characteristics or statistical recurrence analysis. Its own future-work section calls for formal controlled experiments. The framework should preserve that distinction whenever it cites the report.

Safety: this document analyzes claims and research. It is not an instruction to use DMT or to reproduce the protocol. Drug laws and health risks vary, and laser exposure can injure eyes.